

A table-map brief

Filigree for the Table

What two posts and a Swiss layer stack
actually ask a Dungeons & Dragons map to do,
and why the zoom feels smooth.

3 October 2026

Sources: Patrick Collison, Azlen, map.geo.admin.ch, Bay Atlas

Two posts, one national stack

Patrick Collison, 29 September 2026: online maps elide detail on high-DPI screens, and he wants to wallow in cartographic filigree. The demo is Bay Atlas, the Sonoma coast, drawn in a style after swisstopo. Azlen, 1 October 2026, quoting that post: a call for new aesthetics of maps, a thirteen-second painted flyover of San Francisco. Under Collison, a Swiss reply drops map.geo.admin.ch. The link in play is that viewer at national zoom, centered near LV95 2,660,000 / 1,190,000, over central Switzerland, with the 1864 survey, every building, transit stops, hiking paths, shooting-range notices, and trail closures on the color national map.

The posts are a complaint that web maps sand the world down to six labels, and a reply that says the fix is a new aesthetic, not a busier Google tile. The Swiss link is the counterexample: one sheet, six live layers, no mercy. That stack is what a table map should feel like.

Plate one

The first plate is the one that matters. Coast on the left, a rust road glued to the cliffs, ocean a flat blue. Inland, contour filigree so tight the ridges read as fingerprints. Every knoll has a name and a height: Table Mountain 1,581, Devils Ribs 1,900, Goat Rock, Big Oat 1,365, Little Oat 1,381, Pole Mountain 2,205, Black Mountain 1,617. Homesteads are dots, not towns: Toner's Place, Truth Home, Hale Place, Camp Thayer, Seaview. Green washes mark reserves: Fort Ross, Jenner Headlands, Austin Creek. The only real settlement is a knot in the river valley at lower right: Guerneville, Rio Nido, Villa Grande, Monte Rio, highway shields, a braided river. Nothing is generalized. A shed-scale name sits in the same ink as a peak.

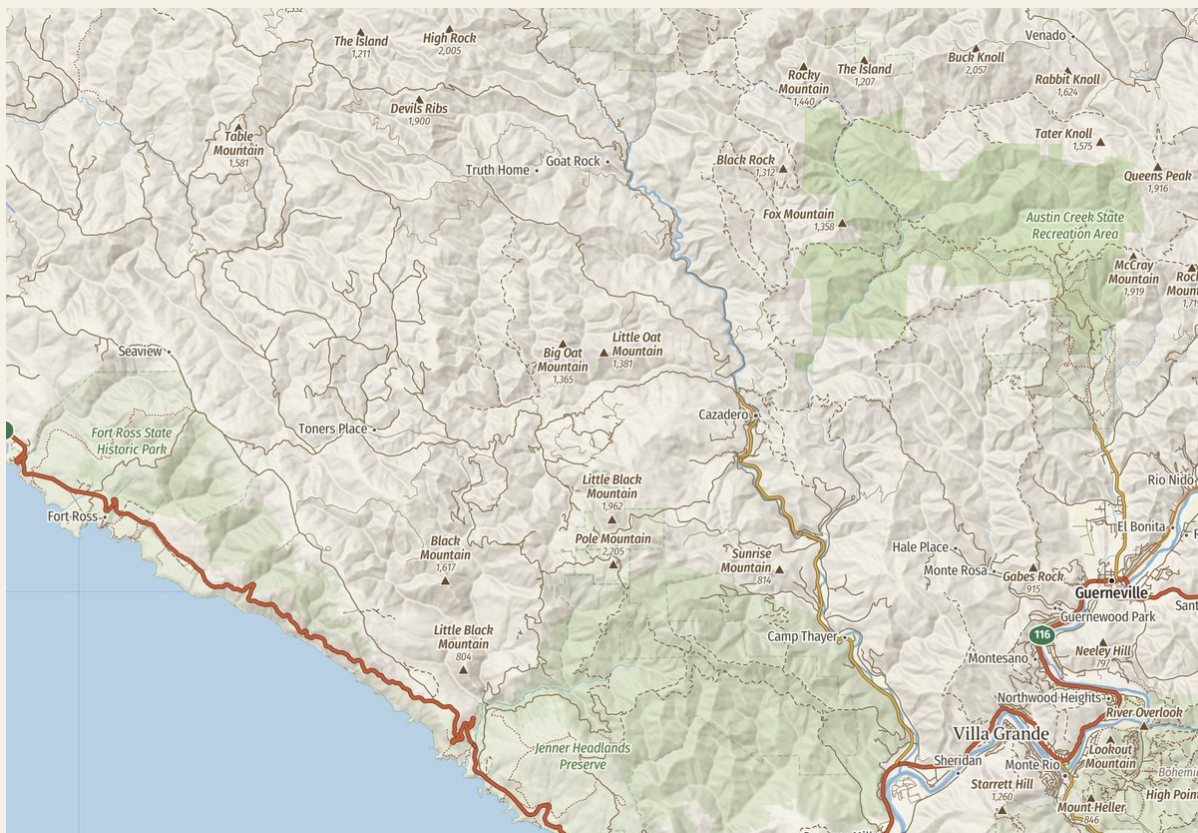


Plate one. Bay Atlas, Swiss style, Sonoma coast. Names and heights on every ridge. This is the density the other two plates refuse.

Plates two and three

Same ground, default terrain. Queens Peak, Pole Mountain, Cazadero, Guerneville, two parks. The ridges are still there. The names are gone. The third plate is paler still: Goat Rock, Toners Place, Dreamwood, Camp Thayer, a retreat pin, a highway. The land has been wiped. Collison's argument is the gap between plate one and these two. The crime is omission.



Plate two. The same coast in default terrain. Relief survives. Almost every name does not.

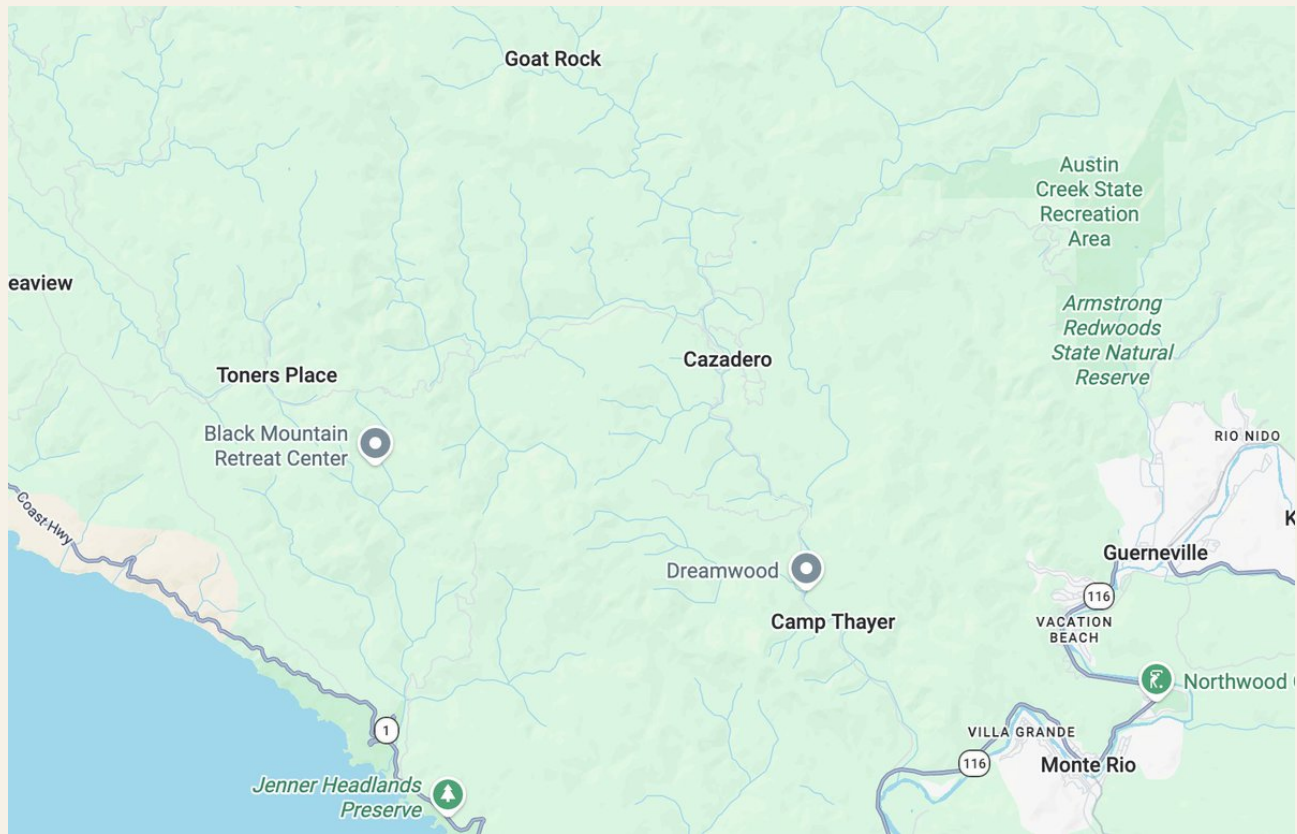


Plate three. Paler again. A handful of labels, a pin, a shield. This is the map that makes plate one feel indecent.

The painted city

Azlen's clip does not add labels. It changes the hand. San Francisco from the bay: peninsula as a cream sheet, blocks in rose-brown grain, parks as green voids, hills on the west drawn with contour hair. Arterials in ocher. Water is watercolor, not a flat fill. Zoom in and the grid becomes a textile. Zoom out and fog washes sit on the east bay and Marin headlands like someone left the brush wet. No UI chrome, no pins. The claim is that density without a new aesthetic is just noise, and the aesthetic he wants is a painted atlas, not an app. A reply under the post noticed the practical trick: contrast gathers at edges because that is where the paint pooled.

That clip is not a live map. It is a camera move over a painted sheet. The blocks were already there. Zooming reveals pixels. Pretty, and the wrong model for what appears at a given scale.

The Swiss stack

The geo.admin link is the grown-up version of both posts. Zoom 1 is the whole country, so the center is a viewport, not a town. The stack under it is the part worth copying.

Layer	On the Swiss sheet	At the table
1864 Zeitreihen	Old survey under the modern sheet. Dead roads, old spellings, forest that grew back.	The ruined map. What the land was called before the living sheet.
Building register	Every structure, including the sheds no gazetteer bothers with.	Footprints. A homestead is a dot with a name, not a town icon.
Transit stops	Public-transport halts, drawn as a network rather than a suggestion.	Coach posts, ferries, waystations. The only places a shield is earned.

Layer	On the Swiss sheet	At the table
Marked paths	Blazed hiking routes, not a vague trail exists.	The path the party can follow without a guide.
Schiessanzeigen	Live shooting-range notices. Hazard that turns on and off.	Range days, dragon flights, artillery hours. Swap between sessions.
Closures	Trail closures and the detour that replaces them.	The road they expect is shut this week. Trespass is a choice.
Color base map	National pixel map. Relief already drawn.	Contours first. Names second. Never the other way around.

Read for the table: a coast of named ribs and forgotten homesteads, a river town that is the only place with a shield, a painted city whose blocks are texture rather than labels, and a overlay for what is closed, what is firing, and what the 1864 sheet still remembers.

Four workflows

Split the work, do not blend it

Each block below is a job with its own input, its own output, and a done-when. Hand them off separately. Do not let planning start before the density bible exists, and do not let review become a vibe check.

1. Research

Input: these three plates, the Swiss layer list, and whatever region the campaign already uses. Output: a density bible, not a map. Walk the real coast once and list what plate one bothers to name — peak, height, homestead, reserve, river fork, coast road — and what plates two and three delete. Do the same for a city quarter in Azlen's grain: block, park void, arterial, fog wash, contour hill. Pull the Swiss stack across and rename the layers in fiction: old survey, every structure, coach posts, blazed paths, range days, closures.

Done when you can point at a blank hex and say which six things must appear on it before it is allowed to be empty.

2. Planning

Input: the density bible and the region. Output: a sheet spec. Pick one coast, one river town, one painted city. Set label ranks: peaks and heights always, homesteads as dots, reserves as a green wash, only the river town gets a shield. Decide the Azlen rule for the city: texture over type, fog as weather not as art. Lock the overlay order so the 1864 sheet sits under the live one, and closures and range notices sit on top and can be swapped between sessions. Name the palette: bone paper, rust coast road, ocher arterials, rose-brown blocks, wet-blue water.

Done when a cartographer who has not seen the posts could draw sheet one from the spec alone.

3. Implementation

Input: the sheet spec. Output: the table map. Draw relief first, contours tight enough to read as fingerprints, then water, then the rust coast road, then green reserves, then homestead dots, then names and heights, then the city grain and fog washes last. Build the overlays as separate sheets: old survey, structures, coach posts, blazed paths, range days, closures. Do not generalize a ridge to save ink. If a knoll has no name, invent one. The crime in plates two and three is omission.

Done when you can cover the settlement with a hand and still navigate by ridge names.

4. Review

Input: the finished sheet plus the three plates and the Swiss layer list. Output: a punch list. Check density against plate one, not against a normal virtual-tabletop map. Check the city against Azlen: does it look painted, or like a UI. Check the stack: can you pull the 1864 sheet, the closures, and the range notice without redrawing. Read every name aloud. Anything you cannot say at the table gets cut or rewritten. Mark the holes where you flinched and generalized.

Done when the sparse version of your own map makes you angry.

How people are using it

Showing, not shipping

Nobody in the threads is using Bay Atlas as a product. Bookmarks on Collison's post outrun the reposts, and the replies are other maps, not bug reports. The post is being used as permission. A Swiss reply drops map.geo.admin.ch, the official stack with the 1864 survey still under the live sheet. Evan Applegate answers the filigree line with his own gilded sheets at radiantmaps.co. Casey Handmer says he already has a private mapping app with more than 160 layers, and only about 5 percent of them are personal. Under Azlen, someone says the painted flyover is a lot like earth.cyr.is. Matt Webb points at Stamen Watercolor and calls it ahead of its time. A map-maker links Cartique and shrugs that it is for hobbits fantasizing about the world outside.

What they like

The likes are narrow. The Swiss style itself. The speed of the Bay Atlas viewer. The way detail arrives instead of being dumped on: one reply under Azlen singles out the subtle appear effect. Rasmus Andersson likes the watercolor for a practical reason. Contrast gathers at the edges because that is where the paint pooled, so the coast and the parks read without a stroke. The sharpest take is that density was always a product decision. Maps built to answer where do I turn were never going to answer what is around me. High-DPI screens and cheaper drawing only removed the excuse.

The tweaks

The pushback is a fight about that decision, not about taste. One reply wants the opposite of filigree: the thing I came for, fast, without playing where's Waldo in the labels. Another wants the colors to be the real colors of the land, not a style palette, because a depiction is how the place gets perceived. Under Azlen, someone sees the vision and still hates it. Cramped. Someone else says pretty maps do not fix bad data. A third notes that Google and Apple still drop street names even when you are zoomed in, so the aesthetic argument sits downstream of a data argument. The split is atlas readers versus navigation users. The first want every knoll named. The second think that is clutter.

The trend

Swiss relief is the prestige look again. Eduard Imhof's hillshade, light from the upper left and cool shadow in the valleys, is what MapTiler's Landscape style imitates with machine learning, and what the OSM Swiss Style talk at State of the Map was rebuilding on OpenStreetMap: transit ranked with roads, vector tiles, hillshade from swissALTI3D, labels ranked so the far sheet stays quiet. A QGIS conference talk this month is just how to style Swiss Map Vector 25. Multi-layer road dashes, buildings drawn under or over the railway, hachures that follow the rock, selective label masking. Vectormap is the same instinct in a file format: official Swiss cadastral data as PMTiles, style separate from the geometry, so the country can be reskinned without being hosted.

Two camps, and the people who like both keep them apart. One camp paints the sheet so it feels held: watercolor, fog washes, bone paper, edge contrast from pooled ink. The other ranks the ink so the far zoom stays almost empty and the valley zoom gets indecent. Paint on the base. Names on a threshold. The people who hate it want one sheet that answers one question.

The smoothness is a camera over a stack

Nothing on those pages is one drawing that grows more detail. The view moves continuously. The content steps, then the renderer hides the step.

Bay Atlas is the cleaner of the two. It is MapLibre GL, with the tiles packed as PMTiles, styled after swisstopo, relief from Mapzen terrain tiles, OpenStreetMap underneath. The hash in Collison's follow-up link, #9/37.75/-122.25, is zoom 9 centered on the Bay. Zoom is a real number, not a click-stop, so 9.4 is a legal view. Each zoom level is a pyramid: the world doubles in width every integer step, and only the tiles on screen get fetched. The geometry in those tiles is already generalized. Contours, land cover, boundaries, and labels are separate layers with a minimum zoom and a maximum zoom, so a homestead name is not added by the browser. It is a layer whose style says it does not exist below a certain scale. Between those integers, MapLibre interpolates line width, text size, and opacity against the fractional zoom. That is the part that feels wet. The data pops in on a threshold. The ink eases.

The Swiss viewer is the older, meaner version of the same idea. The link in question is mostly raster: the color national map, the 1864 Zeitreihen sheet, buildings, stops, paths, ranges, closures. Those are WMTS pyramids. swisstopo did not simplify a master file in the browser. Cartographers drew a different map for each scale, then cut it into tiles. At national zoom you get the country sheet. Zoom in and the client swaps to a larger-scale sheet, where contours tighten, names appear, and buildings stop being a wash and become footprints. The camera still glides, and new tiles crossfade over old ones, which is why it does not blink. Under that, the newer vector service does what Bay Atlas does: Mapbox vector tiles plus a MapLibre style, with the base tileset cartographically adapted per zoom. Past the last authored level the tiles just stretch. That overzoom is the slight softness you get if you push past the printed scale.

Piece	What it does	Why it feels smooth
Tile pyramid	Each integer zoom doubles the map. Only tiles on screen are fetched.	The camera never waits for a new page. It waits for four children of the tile you already have.
Generalized geometry	A river at zoom 6 is a few vertices. The same river at zoom 12 has the bends.	Detail arrives as a different drawing, not as the far sheet suddenly growing labels.
minzoom / maxzoom	A homestead layer is forbidden below a scale. Contours have their own gate.	Names do not fade in from nothing. A layer is either in the style or it is not.
Fractional zoom	Zoom 9.4 is legal. Line width, type size, and opacity interpolate between stops.	This is the wet part. The data steps. The ink eases.
Crossfade	New tiles paint over old ones instead of blinking the sheet blank.	Swiss raster sheets swap scale this way. The glide hides the cut.
Overzoom	Past the last authored level, the last tiles stretch.	The softness past the printed scale. Not new detail. A lie with good manners.

What to steal

Steal the threshold, not the glide. Author three or four sheets of the same ground: country, region, valley, street. Decide what is forbidden on each. The smooth feeling is just refusing to show the next sheet until the eye is close enough that the new ink has room.

- Country sheet. Peaks, the coast road, the river, one shield on the only town. No homesteads.
- Region sheet. Ridge names and heights. Reserves as a wash. The rust road still continuous.
- Valley sheet. Homestead dots, contour hair, river forks, the blazed path.
- City sheet. Block grain, park voids, other arterials, fog as weather. Texture before type.
- Overlays, any scale. Old survey under. Closures and range days on top, swappable between sessions.

At the table

Open on the country sheet. The party should be able to name the coast, the river, and the one town with a shield, and nothing smaller. When they commit to a valley, swap to the region sheet and let the ridge names arrive. Homesteads wait for the valley sheet. The city is a different object: do not label every block. Let them navigate by park, arterial, and the fog.

Keep the overlays in reach, not on the base drawing. The 1864 sheet is what an old local calls the road. The closure slip is what the innkeeper says is shut this week. The range notice is the hazard that was not there yesterday. If a name cannot be said aloud, it does not go on the sheet.

Sources. Patrick Collison, 29 September 2026, on cartographic filigree, Bay Atlas. Replies from Flurin Laim, Evan Applegate, Casey Handmer. Azlen, 1 October 2026, a call for new aesthetics of maps; Matt Webb on Stamen Watercolor; Rasmus Andersson on paint pooling. map.geo.admin.ch at national zoom. Related work: OSM Swiss Style, MapTiler Landscape, Vectormap, Swiss Map Vector 25. Bay Atlas client: MapLibre GL, PMTiles, style after swisstopo.